

# Partnering to Turn Community Wisdom Into Action

Corporate • Educational • Governmental • Community • Philanthropic • Media • Financial & Investment Ecosystem

MYKNXNS Community Development Organization brings residents, institutions, resources, and lived experience together to preserve what matters, understand what communities want to achieve, and help translate those insights into initiatives that create opportunity and lasting impact.

THE PARTNERSHIP IDEA

We do not enter communities assuming we already know the answer. We research, engage, listen, learn, co-create, implement, measure, and improve—working with the people and institutions already invested in the community.

WHY PARTNERSHIP MATTERS

**No single organization can build stronger communities alone.** The value of MYKNXNS C.D.O. is not simply in convening partners or collecting stories. It is in creating a pathway through which community knowledge, institutional expertise, funding, relationships, volunteers, and other resources can work together around outcomes communities identify as important.

## Our Partnership Model



**The result:** partnerships are connected to a full cycle of community engagement—not a one-time event. We learn from the work, evaluate whether it is producing the intended results, and use those lessons to improve what comes next.

# What Different Partners Gain—and How They Can Engage

Partnerships are designed around mutual value. Each partner brings different assets, expertise, relationships, and capabilities; MYKNXNS C.D.O. helps connect those strengths to community-defined priorities and measurable work.

## CORPORATE & BUSINESS PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** A credible way to connect community investment, employee engagement, expertise, products/services, and local relationships to visible community priorities.

- Community-facing activation beyond logo placement or transactional sponsorship.
- Employee volunteer, mentoring, skills-based service, and leadership opportunities.
- Opportunities to support education, veterans, families, entrepreneurs, cultural preservation, and other aligned initiatives.
- Local insight that can deepen understanding of communities the company serves.
- Clearer impact stories, outcomes, and stewardship for community-investment dollars.

**Ways to contribute:** Funding and sponsorship • employee volunteers • in-kind products/services • technical expertise • facilities • mentorship • local introductions

## EDUCATIONAL PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** A real-world bridge between learning, community service, research, storytelling, career readiness, and intergenerational knowledge.

- Experiential-learning opportunities for students and emerging leaders.
- Internships, service learning, community-based research, oral history, and faculty engagement.
- Connections between students and residents, elders, veterans, entrepreneurs, civic leaders, employers and the broader community as a whole.
- Opportunities to preserve institutional and community history while developing practical skills.
- A platform for translating classroom knowledge into community-facing work.

**Ways to contribute:** Student participation • faculty expertise • research • venues • archives • service learning • internships • alumni networks

## GOVERNMENT & CIVIC PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** An additional community-engagement channel that helps connect public institutions with residents, nonprofits, businesses, educators, faith communities, veterans, and other stakeholders—while preserving the people, initiatives, decisions, and lessons that contribute to a community's progress.

- Structured listening and community-engagement opportunities.
- A mechanism for surfacing community priorities, assets, and partnership opportunities.
- Support for initiatives that complement public goals without replacing government responsibility.
- Greater visibility into organizations and residents already doing meaningful local work.
- Documented feedback, participation, lessons learned, and community outcomes.
- Preserve the stories, experiences, leadership, and contributions of the people driving community initiatives—creating a lasting record of what was attempted, what was learned, what worked, and who helped move the community forward.

**Ways to contribute:** Convening • agency expertise • community referrals • public facilities • program alignment • civic participation • local data

## NONPROFIT, FAITH & COMMUNITY PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** A collaborative platform that can amplify existing work, bring new partners to the table, preserve community knowledge, and mobilize people around shared priorities.

- Greater visibility for organizations already trusted in the community.
- Access to volunteers, institutional relationships, storytelling capacity, and potential resources.
- Opportunities to identify and co-develop initiatives instead of duplicating existing services.
- Preservation of lived experience, traditions, wisdom, and local history.
- Follow-through that connects listening to action and action to evaluation.

**Ways to contribute:** Local knowledge • trusted relationships • participant recruitment • service delivery • volunteers • venues • initiative leadership

## PHILANTHROPIC, FOUNDATION & DONOR PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** A way to support both direct community outcomes and the infrastructure required to listen, coordinate, implement, measure, and improve responsibly.

- Funding can support initiatives rooted in community-identified priorities rather than assumptions.
- A portfolio of community, cultural-preservation, education, leadership-development, and service opportunities.
- Measurement that combines quantitative outputs with community voice and lived experience.
- Opportunities to fund pilots, scale effective approaches, and strengthen local organizations and emerging leaders.
- Stewardship through documented activities, outcomes, lessons, and future recommendations.

**Ways to contribute:** Grants • unrestricted support • program funding • challenge grants • capacity building • evaluation support • introductions

## MEDIA, CULTURAL & STORYTELLING PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** Access to meaningful local stories and community voices while helping preserve history, elevate lived experience, and broaden public understanding.

- Community-centered stories with context, dignity, and purpose.
- Opportunities to spotlight educators, veterans, elders, entrepreneurs, families, faith leaders, and everyday people.
- Partnership around oral history, archives, exhibitions, screenings, public conversations, and educational content.
- A pathway for stories to inspire participation and inform community initiatives—not simply generate attention.

**Ways to contribute:** Editorial collaboration • archives • production • exhibits • distribution • event coverage • storytelling expertise

## FINANCIAL & INVESTMENT ECOSYSTEM PARTNERS

**PARTNER VALUE:** A pathway to connect financial knowledge, entrepreneurship support, capital access, and economic opportunity to needs and ambitions identified within communities.

- Opportunities to support financial literacy, entrepreneurship, small-business development, career exposure, and wealth-building education.
- Connections with local entrepreneurs, community organizations, students, and emerging leaders.
- Potential to contribute mentors, financial expertise, technical assistance, and responsible capital-access education.
- Insight into barriers and opportunities surfaced directly through community engagement.

**Ways to contribute:** Financial education • mentors • technical assistance • entrepreneurship support • community-development capital • banking access • business networks

# What Partnership Can Produce

The exact initiative should vary by community. The common objective is to combine local knowledge with partner capabilities to produce work that communities recognize as useful, relevant, and worth sustaining.

|                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PRESERVE</b><br><br>Stories, traditions, wisdom, lived experiences, and local history that might otherwise be lost.                     | <b>CONNECT</b><br><br>Residents and organizations that may share goals but do not yet have a working relationship.                    |
| <b>DEVELOP</b><br><br>Young people and emerging leaders through real responsibility, mentorship, exposure, and service.                    | <b>CREATE</b><br><br>Community initiatives shaped by what residents and local partners say matters.                                   |
| <b>OPEN DOORS</b><br><br>To education, employment, entrepreneurship, mentorship, service, cultural participation, and other opportunities. | <b>STRENGTHEN</b><br><br>Local organizations and relationships by directing attention and resources toward existing community assets. |
| <b>MEASURE</b><br><br>Participation, outputs, feedback, outcomes, commitments, and lessons—not simply activity.                            | <b>IMPROVE</b><br><br>Future initiatives by identifying what worked, what did not, why, and what should change.                       |

## Examples of Partnership in Action

- An HBCU, local employer, and community nonprofit collaborate on a student-led oral-history and career-readiness initiative.
- A city agency, veteran organization, corporate sponsor, and local museum preserve veteran experiences while connecting participants to services and opportunities.
- A chamber of commerce, financial institution, university, and neighborhood organization use entrepreneur stories and listening sessions to shape a small-business support initiative.
- A faith organization, school, family-services nonprofit, and funder identify a community priority, mobilize volunteers and resources, test an initiative, and evaluate the results.
- A museum, media partner, local historians, residents, and MYKNXNS C.D.O. preserve community history and use what is learned to inform education and public engagement.

### IMPORTANT STRUCTURAL DISTINCTION

MYKNXNS C.D.O. is the nonprofit community-impact vehicle. Donations, grants, sponsorships, volunteer support, and in-kind contributions intended for charitable/community programming should be structured through the C.D.O. as appropriate. Equity or other investment in MYKNXNS Inc. is separate from charitable support of the C.D.O.; the two should not be presented as interchangeable.

## A Simple Partnership Path

1. **ALIGN** - Identify the community, issue, population, or outcome where interests overlap.
2. **LISTEN** - Engage residents and local organizations to understand priorities, assets, and existing work.
3. **DESIGN** - Define the initiative, roles, resources, desired outcomes, safeguards, and measures of success.
4. **ACT** - Mobilize partners, people, funding, expertise, and other resources to implement.
5. **EVALUATE** - Measure progress, gather community and partner feedback, and compare results with intended outcomes.
6. **LEARN & IMPROVE** - Document lessons, refine the model, strengthen relationships, and determine whether to sustain, expand, redesign, or conclude the initiative.

## What We Ask of Every Partner

- Come prepared to listen as well as contribute.
- Respect the knowledge, dignity, privacy, and agency of the people whose communities and stories are involved.
- Be clear about what you can contribute and what success should look like.
- Avoid duplicating work that trusted local organizations are already doing well.
- Share responsibility for follow-through, measurement, learning, and improvement.
- Focus on sustainable value—not simply visibility, attendance, or a one-time activation.

### THE OPPORTUNITY

A partnership with MYKNXNS C.D.O. is an opportunity to do more than support a program. It is an opportunity to listen to communities, preserve what they know, connect resources to what they value, develop people, create practical initiatives, measure what changes, and keep learning how to serve better.

**Preserve Connections. Protect Legacy. Empower Generations.**